Gays protest military policy

Lisa Funk
Daily Texan Staff

Four gay and lesbian groups, a state representative and Veterans for Peace joined Friday to voice their opposition to the U.S. military's discrimination against non-heterosexuals as a kick-off for the National Day of Action.

"The military regulation against gay, lesbian and bisexual personnel is steeped in prejudice that must be eliminated for people to progress and work together effectively within and outside the military," said Susan Warshauer, of Austin AIDS Coalition to Unleash Power (ACT UP).

Bill Craven, a representative of Coalition of Lesbian/Gay Student Groups, announced that the coalition's UT chapter and Oklahoma schools chapters drafted letters to Gov. Ann Richards urging her to appoint homosexuals and people understanding of homosexual causes to state boards and commissions.

The letter states that appointees could then work to eliminate "active discrimination against homosexuals practiced by the U.S. Department of Defense at campuses across the country, particularly in its Reserve Officers Training Corps (ROTC) and GI Bill programs."

"We ask you to fulfill the promise of an inclusive society which is implicit in the best traditions of the United States," the letter adds.

"The military is about to take a big hit," said Craven, a graduate student at the University. "MIT said that no student who participates in ROTC shall have access to that university in three years, because of the military policy."

Craven added that although the University has a general anti-discrimination code, the wording of the code cannot be used to eliminate the ROTC or ROTC harassment from campus.

Warshauer said the military uses a Department of Defense directive to harass and deny job positions and veteran benefits to gay and lesbian personnel and that such actions "create an atmosphere that lends itself to queer-bashing."

Jon Littell, a representative of Queer Nation, agreed. "Homophobia, like all forms of intolerance and bigotry, is a learned behavior," he said. "The military's policy of discrimination sets forth the example of intolerance against queers.

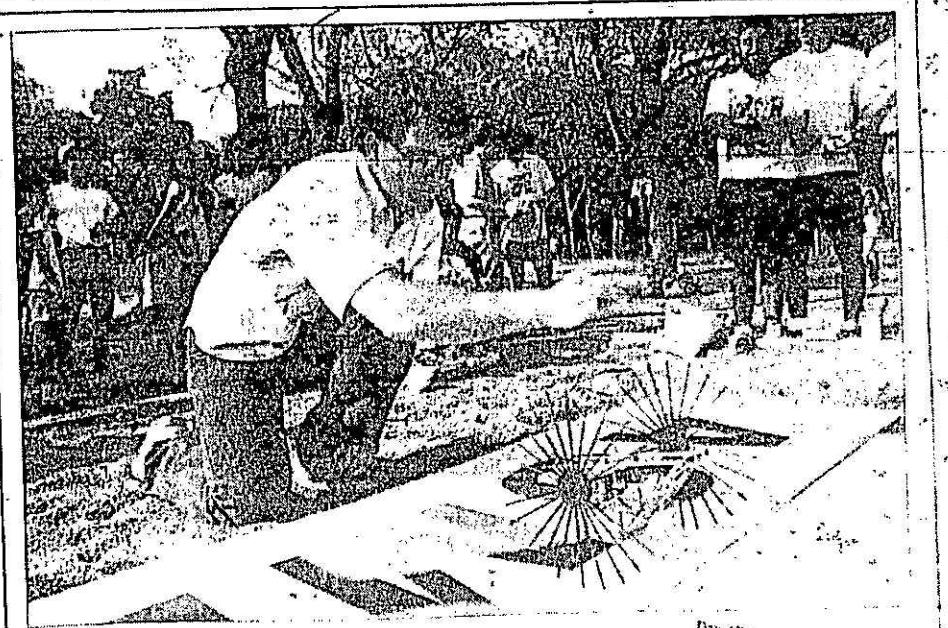
"Queer Nation demands that this policy of discrimination be rescinded."

Rep. Glen Maxey said a state criminal statute against homosexual conduct is the "linchpin" that permits discrimination to continue in Texas. "You begin sending a message to the people that you shouldn't talk to the government; you shouldn't trust the government. That's the wrong message."

Laurie Eiserloh of The Lesbian/Gay Rights Lobby of Texas, said the Department of Defense has produced reports favorable to the integration of homosexuals in the military. But she added that "once these reports were completed, the military refused to release them."

Eiserloh said the efforts of U.S. Rep. Gerry Studds, D-Mass., and Pat Schroeder, D-Colo., brought the reports into the public record.

Doug Zachary, a representative of Veterans for Peace, an organization that advocates the elimination of violence as an instrument of foreign policy, called military practices "systems of oppression."



David Fitzgerald/Daily Texan Staff

A whirlin' dervish

Kyle Watson, a mechanical engineering graduate student, demonstrated his rubber band-powered vehicle in a contest sponsored by the American Society of Mechanical Engineers in Eastwoods Park Friday. Contestants built vehicles powered by two rubber bands in hopes of conquering a hill and water trap the fastest.

Board listens to Tavern alternatives